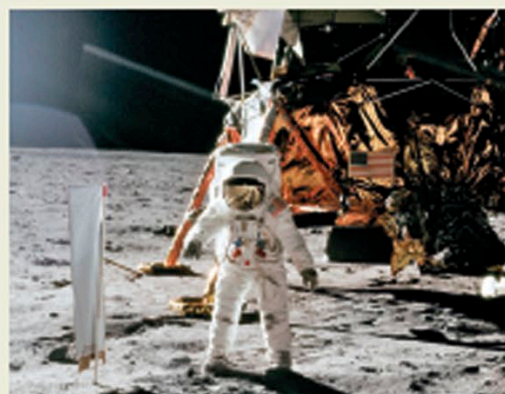


The Apollo missions

The US made manned exploration of the Moon their major goal. Six of the seven Apollo missions (1969–1972) managed to each place two astronauts on the lunar surface using a lunar module, with a third astronaut in the command module orbiting the Moon and awaiting their return. The missions, followed by millions of people on Earth, returned 840 lb (382 kg) of Moon rock and soil for analysis.

Apollo 11 launches

In 1969, the world's largest, most powerful launch vehicle, the Saturn V, blasted off carrying the Apollo 11 spacecraft. The 363-ft- (110.6-m-) tall rocket weighed 6.3 million lb (2.9 million kg) and featured 11 different rocket engines in three stages, which each fell away when their fuel was exhausted, reducing weight. The first stage's engines used at lift-off generated 7.6 million lb (3.47 million kg) of thrust.



First people on the Moon

American astronauts Neil Armstrong and Edwin "Buzz" Aldrin became the first humans to set foot on the Moon on July 20, 1969 during the Apollo 11 mission. The lunar module in which they descended to the Moon spent 21 hours on the lunar surface.



Lunar rovers

Carried on the Apollo 15, 16, and 17 missions, lunar rovers could transport two astronauts plus equipment over the Moon's surface at a maximum speed of 13 mph (8 km/h). A pair of 36-volt batteries powered an electric motor on each wheel of the rover.

Joint mission

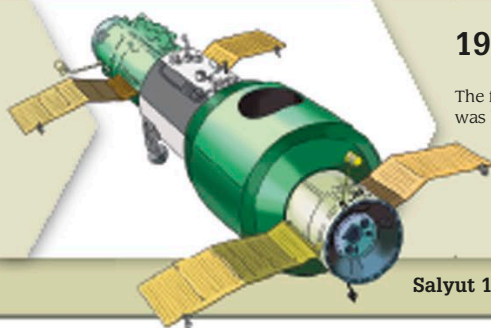
In 1975, the space race ended as the US and the Soviet Union cooperated to dock a Soviet Soyuz spacecraft with an American Apollo module. A crew of five astronauts performed experiments during the 44 hours of docking.



Apollo 11 launches from the Kennedy Space Center, Cape Canaveral, 1969

1970

The Soviet craft Lunokhod 1 became the first successful space rover. It travelled 10,540 m (34,580 ft) across the Moon's surface.



Salyut 1

1971

The first space station, Salyut 1, was launched by the Soviet Union. It orbited Earth for 175 days. Space stations provide long-term bases for astronauts in space.

1972

American astronaut Eugene Cernan, commander of Apollo 17, was the last person to stand on the Moon. No one has visited since.